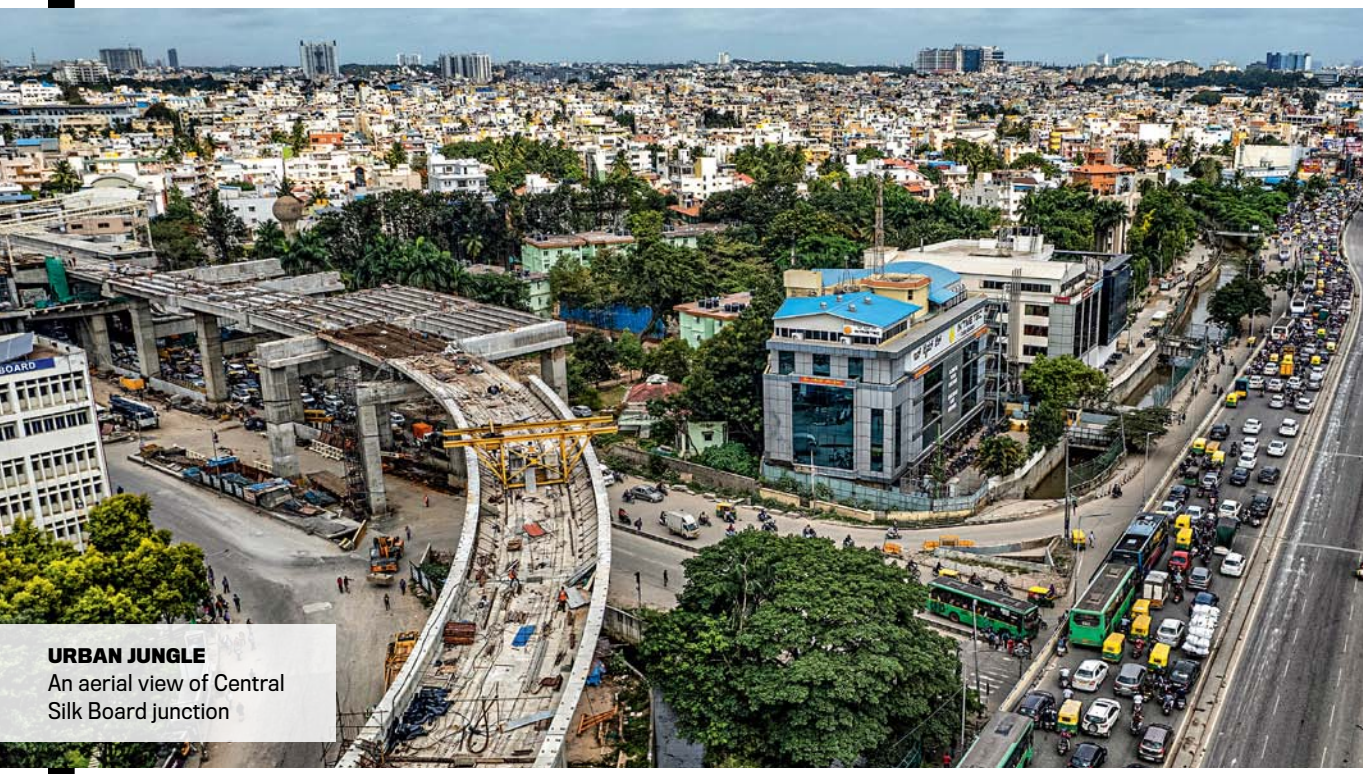
BANDEEP SINGH



URBAN JUNGLE
An aerial view of Central Silk Board junction

BENGALURU METRO

ON THE SLOW TRACK

55.9
KM
Length of tracks completed since 2011

119.5
KM
Length of tracks to be completed by 2025

10
PER CENT
of the city's 4 million commuters use the metro daily

Source: BMRCL

TRANSPORT

RETARDED GROWTH

0
Buses the Bangalore Metropolitan Transport Corporation added to its fleet of 6,521 from 2014-15 to 2020-21

3
MILLION
No. of private vehicles added due to insufficient public bus transport system during the same period

Source: BMTC/Transport dept

in the city. The result: there is very little first- or last-mile connectivity for commuters to move seamlessly from bus to train and vice versa, to ease congestion and ensure convenience, forcing them instead to rely on autorickshaws and taxis to get to their destinations. One reason is that when the metro project, a joint venture between the central and state governments, was set up in 1994, it decided that much of the rails will be overground to save costs. That decision ruined some of the landmark avenues in the heart of the city, including the famed MG Road, now marred by monstrous concrete girders running down its middle. In the densely-packed city, much of the network runs parallel to arterial roads where buses also ply, defeating their very purpose.

This is also the reason implementation of the metro project has been slow, as land acquisition for overground rails is cumbersome and time-consuming. The metro finally began operations in 2011. It has so far completed just 56 km, with another 119.4 km to be completed by 2025. The cost so far: Rs 59,328 crore. Currently, the metro handles barely 10 per cent of the total commuting traffic of 4 million and though the BMTC boasts a fleet of 6,521 buses, commuters prefer their own vehicles because of poor connectivity. The city's vehicle population grew by 3 million from 2014-15 to 2020-21; the BMTC did not add even a single bus in that time. As architect Naresh Narasimhan points out, "It costs Rs 340 crore